

scheme: "Since India doesn't have telco contracts or bundled monthly payments, we're a largely prepaid market where affordability has remained an important point, and that has contributed heavily to Apple's iPhone success in India." Step inside an Apple Store and the financing options are made frictionless, which is why conversion rates spike. It isn't a weakness. It's product-market fit.

Singh adds that iPhone shipments were about 12.5 million in 2024 and could touch roughly 15 million this year, nudging Apple into top-five territory by unit shipments despite an average selling price nearly three times the market median.

Brar also flagged how that premium tilt shows up in-store: "Data shows that the ASP for iPhones sold in Mumbai and Delhi trend approximately 8–12% higher than the national average. Customers are buying more Pro models over the non-Pro options, and for Pro users, higher storage options like 256GB or 512GB seem not like a luxury, but a necessity."

It's not just about volume. It's about building a high-value ecosystem in the right postal codes, and Hebbal and Koregaon Park tick those boxes. Counterpoint's Research Director for Devices and Ecosystems Tarun Pathak framed the geography bluntly: "If you look at the top five cities from where the premium smartphone sales comes from, in the order it is Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, Pune and Hyderabad, these five cities contribute close to like 21–22% of the premium smartphone sales and that's exactly the cities where Apple has started to open."

### The cultural landmark

If the Mumbai and Delhi stores taught us anything, it's that Apple's retail spaces quickly become more than places to shop. They double as



civic rooms or what Brar calls "brand temples." "For years, Apple's brand in India was perceived through the lens of third-party resellers. While many are excellent, the experience could be inconsistent. The official stores are what I call 'brand temples.' They help in offering a controlled narrative around the brand and the products."

That controlled narrative shows up in how the spaces are designed. From the Today at Apple sessions such as photography workshops, music jams, iPad sketch lessons, to the Genius Bar, everything is choreographed for immersion. Kawoosa believes this is where Apple stands apart: "Apple is a brand which has pioneered the concept of experiential marketing and I feel today brands need to build experiential connect than any other connect. Emotional and logical connects are fine, but it's experiential connect that results in very strong brand preferences which are hard to replace."

And it isn't just the architecture, it's the people inside it. "The highly trained and professionally mannered promoters at these stores never appear to be selling. They never push. They assist you when you want, educate

you and clear your doubts to arrive at a buying decision," Kawoosa said. That ethos is what makes the stores sticky, particularly for Gen Z, who, he noted, "shop gadgets and devices along with friends and sometimes parents, who still have a say in what they are buying in many cases."

Prabhu Ram sees this as a cultural reset for how Indians buy premium tech: "In a market where touch-and-feel remains central to electronics purchases, physical stores are critical not just for loyal ecosystem customers but also for new consumers drawn to the brand's enduring appeal." This is already visible in Pune, where students are wandering in for workshops, and

in Bengaluru, where startup founders see the store as a ready-made space for demos and community.

### The local impact

The ripple goes deeper than shiny storefronts. Prabhu Ram is bullish on the decade-long arc: "The Apple online store has enabled the brand to tap into aspirational demand for its ecosystem products, not just in urban centers but across Aspirational India." The physical stores, then, deepen that demand in premium hubs. They're less about first-day sales and more about rewiring consumer behaviour.

And this isn't just about retail, it ties directly into Apple's manufacturing push. As Brar explained: "Apple's massive 'Make in India' initiative helps with supply chain resilience and pricing stability, but producing goods locally is only half the battle. You need to create and sustain the demand and brand premium to sell those goods at Apple's desired price point. This is where the offline stores come into play. **d**

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